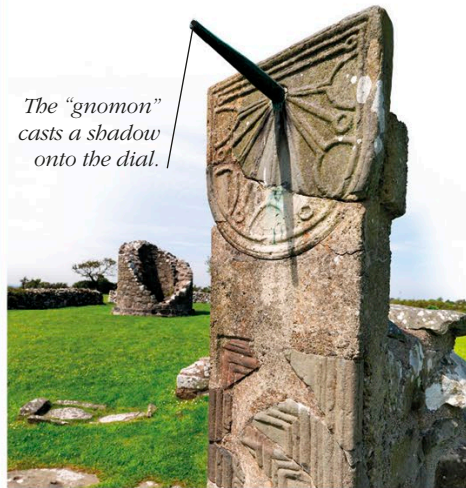


SUNDIALS

Some 3,000 years ago, the astronomers of ancient Egypt used the regular movement of the sun through the sky to tell time. Early Egyptian clocks, called sundials, indicated time by the position of a shadow falling across markers.

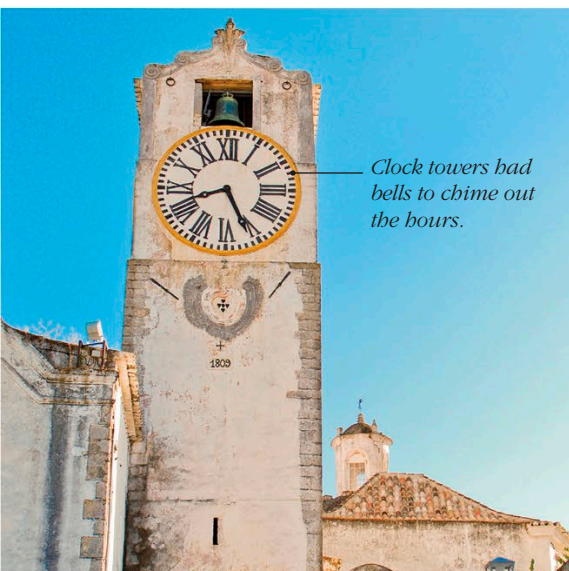


The "gnomon" casts a shadow onto the dial.

9th-century sundial, Northern Ireland

MECHANICAL CLOCKS

The first mechanical clocks were invented in Europe around the start of the 14th century. Nobody had clocks at home, so clocks were put on towers at the center of towns and cities.



Clock towers had bells to chime out the hours.

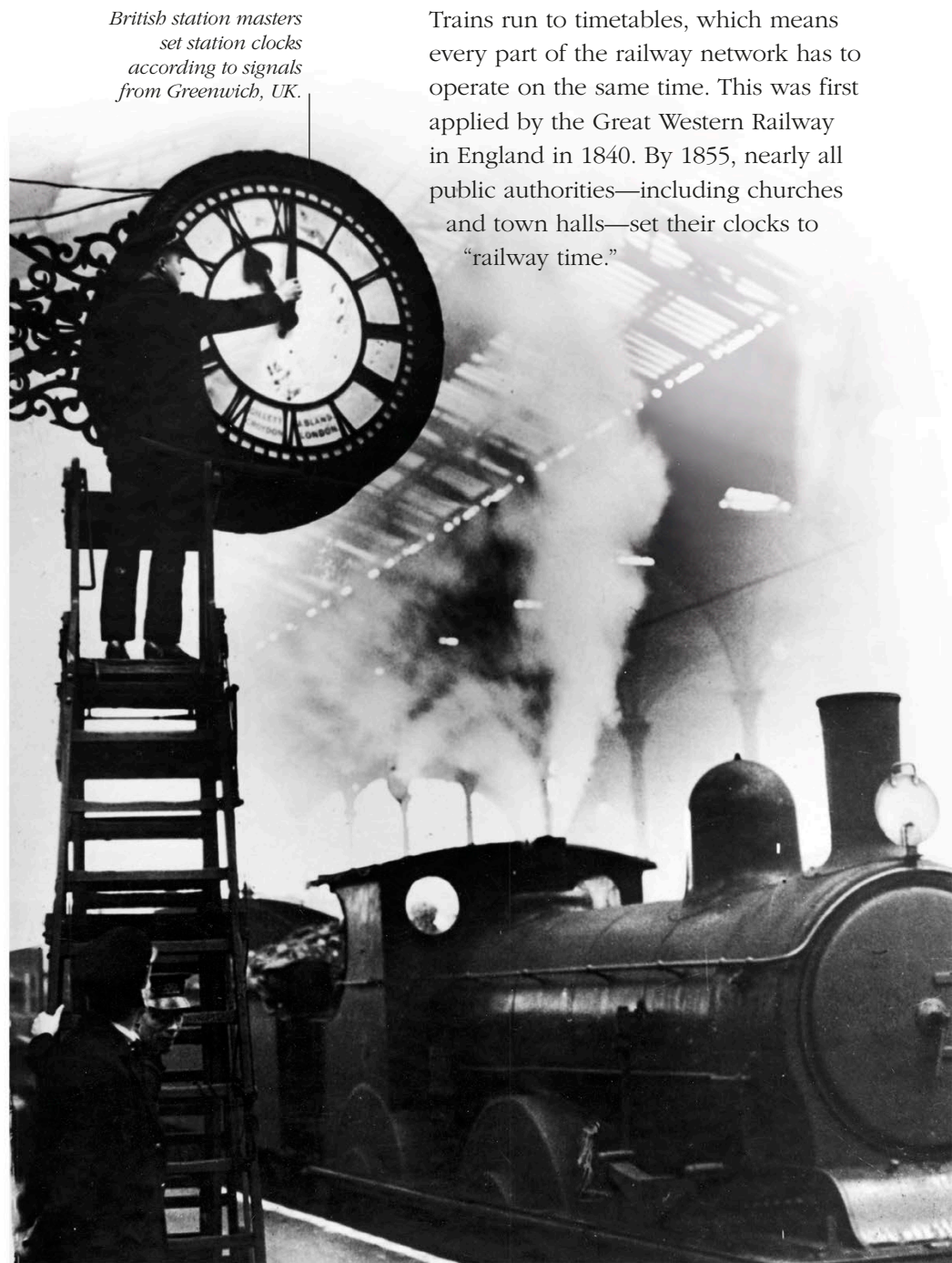
Town clock tower, Tavira, Portugal

Measuring time

Keeping track of time became important as soon as people began to live in towns and cities. Clocks were set by the sun, which meant time differed between locations, even within the same country. This worked up until the arrival of the railways, when train schedules demanded that time be standardized.

STANDARDIZING TIME

Trains run to timetables, which means every part of the railway network has to operate on the same time. This was first applied by the Great Western Railway in England in 1840. By 1855, nearly all public authorities—including churches and town halls—set their clocks to "railway time."



British station masters set station clocks according to signals from Greenwich, UK.